“Dear Eleanor”: Dating Before the Internet

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ATLANTA STADIUM'S MOST SPECTACULAR DAY

One of the most spectacular events ever to occur at Atlanta Stadium was generated by the bat of Henry "Hammerin' Hank" Aaron Monday night. Among the highlights (left, to right) his mightly swing which blasted home run number 715, making him the greatest home run hitter in history; this mighty embrace from his mother; his triumphant clutching of the home run ball as his body guard Det. Sgt. Calvin Wardlaw stood at his side; and a bronze bust of the hero, which will be on display at the downtown Citizens and Southern Savings Bank.

The 46th volume of the Atlanta Daily World newspaper's front page [5]

While looking through *Atlanta Daily World*, we found "Dear Eleanor," an advice column featuring publicly published entry-like questions answered under the pseudonym “Eleanor,” likely by multiple editors. Running from the 1940s for decades, the column has little surviving context today, but it drew thousands of submissions —primarily from Black women in Atlanta—about relationships, family conflict, and social reputation

These private concerns were made public in the "Dear Eleanor" column revealing how Atlanta’s media culture used public advice as a mechanism to enforce gendered expectations and social respectability, shaping dating and family life through collective norms that prioritized community in a way that only makes sense in Atlanta —the Black Mecca of the south, a community using respectability beyond a social preference, and as a shield against a Jim Crow city.

> **In a way, "Dear Eleanor," among many other newspaper articles and columns, influenced Atlanta’s social culture by publicly defining what can be considered a norm.**

I mean, every reader could see what problems other women were bringing forward, and how those problems were judged. This wasn’t just advice; it was a community deciding, in print, what was acceptable and what wasn’t. Women’s behavior became a measure of the community’s moral standing, with “Dear Eleanor” not merely reflecting those expectations but reinforcing them week after week.

Let’s explore four entries in particular, each one revealing a different dimension of the same pressure.

“Dear Eleanor” Advice Column Artifact #1:

Dear Eleanor,

I'm a girl 17 years of age and in love with a boy 20. I love this boy very much and I believe that he loves me. He wants me to "go out" with him. This, I do not wish to do.

This fellow also goes to see a girl who lives near me. Should I quit him or start going out with him?

Worried S. M. M. of Atlanta

ANSWER:

If by the expression "going out' you mean that he is requesting that you indulge in marital relations prior to marriage, he is wrong. It is truly unfair question for you have too much at stake morally, phy-chally, physically and spiritually. Remind him, that if he cannot wait, you will discontinue your friendship.

Eleanor

A 17-year-old girl's declaration of love, published on May 4th, 1952 [1]

This first entry features a 17-year-old girl writing to Eleanor. She asks for advice about a 20-year-old man she’s in love with, wanting to know if she should keep seeing him.

Eleanor’s response, oddly, never addresses the man’s behavior: he’s older, he’s seeing someone else. But none of that registers as a problem worth naming. Rather, Eleanor reframes the question into one of the girl’s morality, suggesting that “going out” implies premarital relations and is therefore wrong, regardless. Eleanor offers the advice to end the relationship, for the sake of the entry writer, for her moral, physical, and spiritual well-being.

In Atlanta’s social context, this guidance isn’t necessarily rooted in old-fashioned prudishness, but in reinforced community ideals of respectability and proper womanhood: how young women were expected to behave both in public and private life. By publishing these responses in a widely read newspaper, the column’s readers, likely other young girls, learn second-hand what responsibility looks like. “Dear Eleanor,” like many of Atlanta’s historical Black press, actively shaped the social norms and moral culture of the city’s community.

But Eleanor’s advice doesn’t just end at teenage dating.

“Dear Eleanor” Advice Column Artifact #2:

Dear Eleanor,

A couple in our neighborhood has been divorced, but both are living in the area. We have no quarrel with either one of them and would like to extend invitations to them for parties we give throughout the year. Are we supposed to make a choice or may we invite them both, so long as we don't invite them together?

Mrs. McMeachem

Answer: Sometimes when a divorce has been what is called "scandalous", it is difficult for people who have been friends of both couples not to make a social choice when both remain in the community. Sometimes those who were first the friends of the husband continue to see him, and those who were, before the marriage, friends of the wife, continue to see her.

Others who knew both equally well sometimes find it necessary to make a choice, but this is only necessary usually when there is a bad feeling between the divorced couple.

A couple's concerns about their divorced neighbors, published on October 21st, 1959 [4[

In our next archive, "Dear Eleanor" shifts from individual relationships of teenage boy troubles to broader community dynamics, showing how social norms governed public behavior within Atlanta's Black community. In this case, a reader asks how to navigate inviting a divorced couple to social gatherings, framing divorce as a potential social disruption. Eleanor's response emphasizes maintaining social order, suggesting that friendships should be managed carefully to avoid conflict and that, in some cases, people may need to "choose sides."

Rather than focusing on the individuals involved, the advice prioritizes preserving harmony within the community. But this is beyond generic etiquette advice; with the backdrop of Atlanta, it's important to pull in the context of the tight-knit Black neighborhoods of mid-century Atlanta, where communities were places of social belonging. The column functioned as a guide for acceptable social conduct, reinforcing expectations about respectability and reputation in Atlanta's black community, and demonstrating how even private matters like divorce were regulated through public norms.

"Dear Eleanor" Advice Column Artifact #3:

Dear Eleanor,

I read your column each week in my home town paper and I do enjoy it very much. Little did I realize that I would be writing you, asking for help to solve my problem.

I was married; but received my divorce about five years ago. There were no children.

A few months ago, I became pregnant and happen not to be married. My father is furiously irate about my predicament ever since he discovered my condition; and he says I can't stay here and disgrace his family. I do know that I must leave the city.

There are homes for unwed white girls. I wish to know where I might go for prenatal care and delivery. Please inform me.

Miss T. of T.

Answer: The Door of Hope, Inc., P. O. Box 9172 can find for you a suitable home here in Atlanta, Ga. Write to Mrs. Thelma G. Session for details.

A pregnant widow's concerns about her social reputation, published on October 17th, 1959 [3]

In this entry, a divorced woman writes to Eleanor regarding her pregnancy outside of marriage, facing the consequences of bringing "disgrace" to her family to the point where she is expected to leave the city.

Rather than questioning this stigma, Eleanor helps her navigate within it by directing her to a home for "unwed white girls."

Unwed white girls—that line alone tells you something newspapers themselves can't quite say out loud. The support structures available to women in crisis in Atlanta were segregated. *Atlanta Daily World*, a black newspaper serving a black community, chose to include this entry, chose to respond to it, and chose to point its readers, who are almost certainly majority Black women, towards an institution that wasn't built for them.

Why?

Well, "Dear Eleanor" itself cannot actually solve social consequences rooted in race, can it? The column can only simply enforce community norms about respectability. In that way, Eleanor uses an unspoken power, one where she routes women, regardless of race, to whatever is available, offering support to all.

"Dear Eleanor" Advice Column Artifact #4:

Dear Eleanor,

I am quite a lonely young divorcee with one child: I'm a college graduate in my late twenties.

I do not drink or smoke: I'm 5 ft. 6 in. tall, and of brown complexion. I love all types of sports and I'm a church member.

I wish to meet some nice young men 29 to 45. They must be mature-minded, and must be single and have excellent health.

In short, I am looking for some one who can be a father for my daughter and not just a husband for myself.

Please help me to meet some eligible gentleman who might have the qualifications specified above.

B. C. D. of Mont.

Answer: Any interested gentlemen who can get a character recommendation letter from the pastor of his church can obtain this young ladies name and address by writing Eleanor at 210 Auburn Ave., N. E., Atlanta, Ga. This letter of recommendation must be written by a reputable minister.

A lonely young woman searching for a suitor, published on Nov 12, 1958 [2]

The last entry we have is quite different from the others, pulled out of the special pen-pal section “Dear Eleanor” features on occasion. Rather than a crisis, the entries open doors to opportunity. A divorced woman writes in to find a new partner. She describes herself in some detail: her education, her religious practice, her physical appearance, her lifestyle. She is actively presenting herself for evaluation.

However, Eleanor’s response adds a requirement: any man who wants to make contact must first obtain a character recommendation from his church pastor.

This is an entry that, among numerous others, most directly anticipates how dating works today, a precursor to modern dating apps. What Eleanor has built here, though, is a credentialing system. The woman has created a profile, opening herself to public evaluation just by writing to the newspaper. Interested men, on the other hand, must be verified by a trusted institution before they can proceed. The church pastor functions exactly the way a background check or a verified badge functions in a modern dating app — as a third-party guarantee of character. But notice who is being credentialed - the system places the burden of proof on men to prove they are trustworthy, yet at the same time places the burden of exposure on women just to participate.

That asymmetry, where women are visible and evaluated, and men require institutional vouching before they engage, is something that hasn't entirely disappeared today.

Conclusion:

Across the twenty years of “Dear Eleanor” columns, we see a consistent pattern: a woman bringing in a personal, private concern to a public forum. Eleanor’s responses do not ask whether the social expectations placed on readers are fair. It takes the expectation as given and only helps readers navigate within it. Community order is preserved, prioritized over individual choice.

What makes this distinctly Atlanta is that it doesn’t end at morality. The Black press in the historical Jim Crow South understood that the behavior of Black individuals was constantly being used as evidence about people of color collectively. Respectability became a survival strategy. A Black woman who caused a "scandal" wasn't just embarrassing her family; in the logic of that era, she was giving ammunition to a white society that was looking for reasons to deny the Black community.

That is what media making looks like when a newspaper column functions as more than just advice. “Dear Eleanor” was doing social work. The column was actively producing Atlanta’s historical norms, calibrating them, week after week, for thousands of readers. That is the power of a platform, whether the platform is a newspaper column in 1945 or an algorithm in 2026.

Works Cited

[1] “Eleanor.” *Atlanta Daily World*, 14 May 1952, p. 2. *ProQuest.*

[2] “Eleanor.” *Atlanta Daily World*, 12 Nov. 1958, p. 2. *ProQuest.*

[3] “Eleanor.” *Atlanta Daily World*, 17 Oct. 1959, p. 6. *ProQuest.*

[4] “Eleanor.” *Atlanta Daily World*, 21 Oct. 1959, p. 3. *ProQuest.*

[5] *Atlanta Daily World.* Vol. 46, no. 140, 11 Apr. 1974, p. 1.